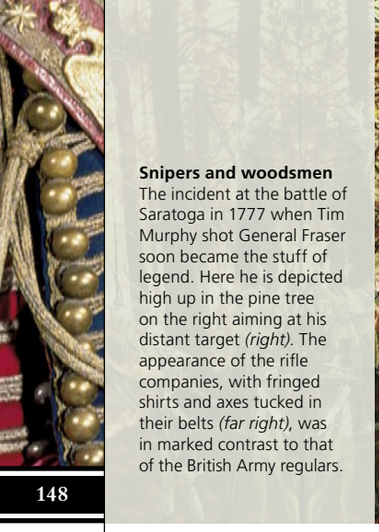






**Snipers and woodsmen**
The incident at the battle of Saratoga in 1777 when Tim Murphy shot General Fraser soon became the stuff of legend. Here he is depicted high up in the pine tree on the right aiming at his distant target *(right)*. The appearance of the rifle companies, with fringed shirts and axes tucked in their belts *(far right)*, was in marked contrast to that of the British Army regulars.

At the same time, the frontiersmen revealed themselves to be a thoroughly undisciplined bunch, given to stealing from ordinary soldiers and disrespectful of all conventional authority. They would, by contrast, faithfully follow officers of their own ilk, such as the formidable Virginian Daniel Morgan, who in his earlier military career in the French and Indian War had survived having most of his teeth blown out by a bullet that passed through his neck and cheek.

The American commander-in-chief, General George Washington, was convinced that only a disciplined army trained and drilled on European lines could beat the British. But he appreciated the frontiersmen's fighting qualities and encouraged Morgan in particular to form and lead bodies of riflemen to act as snipers and skirmishing light infantry. Morgan thoroughly justified the confidence shown in him with a notable contribution to the defeat of the British at Saratoga in 1777. As General John Burgoyne's army advanced south down the Hudson Valley on 19 September, their right flank ran into Morgan's riflemen at Freeman's Farm. Aimed fire directed from woodland across a clearing decimated the British advanced guard, in particular killing almost all of the officers. The riflemen were less successful in attempting to exploit the advantage thus gained, their ill-organized charges being repelled by the disciplined British bayonets. The battle was resumed after a lull on 7 October with a British assault on Bemis Heights. In a famous incident, American General Benedict Arnold called upon Morgan to get rid of one of the ablest British officers, General Simon Fraser, who was bravely riding in the open on a grey horse. One of Morgan's men, a legendary Indian fighter called Tim Murphy, obliged by shooting Fraser dead at a range of some 275m (300 yards). This loss had a crushing effect on British morale, contributing to the failure of their attack and their eventual defeat.

> "MANY OF THEM AT 150 YARDS WILL HIT A CARD NINE TIMES OUT OF TEN."
>
> **BRITISH OFFICER** AT THE SIEGE OF BOSTON, 1775




**Rifleman's haversack**
Accustomed to hunting and living off his wits in the woods of the frontier colonies, the rifleman was much better equipped for most eventualities than any regular soldier.

## UNFAIR TACTICS

The policy of sniping at individual officers was as controversial as it was effective. Morgan, who reputedly tested new recruits by asking them to shoot at a target in the shape of a British officer's head, was regarded by some of his opponents as in effect a war criminal. British Lieutenant William Digby, complaining of this "cowardly and cruel way of carrying on the war" called for snipers to be placed in "the hands of the hangman". The British equally objected to the riflemen's skirmishing style of warfare. The frontiersmen were expert at exploiting cover, firing at will from behind trees, rocks, or walls. They also did not hesitate to hide or run away when facing a counterattack. These tactics were viewed with contempt by British soldiers trained to fire muskets in volleys and stand up to their enemy in the open. One wrote indignantly of the riflemen: "Those people in fair action in open field would signify nothing." Naturally